

New Canon inkjets For Business Use

Canon recently introduced the Pixma range of printers, and we received two of them—the iP3000 and iP4000. They sport revolutionary design—they are appealing, compact and haven't compromised on performance or features.

The iP3000 has four separate ink tanks, whereas the iP4000 has five separate ink tanks. That's the basic difference, apart from the speed ratings.

Both these printers are PictBridge-compliant, so it is possible to print directly from a digital camera.

Duplex printing support is native on



The Canon Pixma iP3000

both printers, and is a boon in business environments—duplex printing saves on paper. It not only reduces costs, it also takes care of your responsibility towards the environment.

One feature that Canon has been pushing hard over the last two generations of

printers is CD-R printing support—it allows you to print a CD face directly on a CD. This feature is useful for people who market material via CD-Rs.

Both the iP3000 and the iP4000 have a dual paper feeding mechanism—one via a paper cassette, and the other via a



The Canon Pixma iP4000

top-loading sheet feeder.

During our tests, we did not come across any paper jams or multiple sheet pickups.

The Pixma iP4000 turned out to be the fastest inkjet we have seen thus far, while the iP3000 is marginally slower. In terms of quality, they live up to the expectations when it comes to

text as well as complex documents with charts and line graphs. Photo printing is deceptively good for these printers; however, for best results, you will need to use the recommended media. Sensibly priced at Rs 6,600 and Rs 7,000 respectively, the iP3000 and the iP4000 are good buys.

Canon sent us their Laser Shot LBP 2410, while HP turned up with the LaserJet 2550L. Both printers use the same internal technology, which has the colour toners mounted on a rotating carousel. Lexmark sent us their C510, Samsung sent in their Ace CLP 500, and Wipro turned up with the 4160 model.

The Features

Printers are often defined by the resolution they support. The Canon, HP and Wipro are rated to provide 600 x 600 native resolutions. This is the native resolution, but you will often find the interpolated resolution mentioned at over 2,400 dpi. Samsung's CLP-500 is rated at 1,200 dpi, whereas Lexmark rates their C510 at 2,400 dpi; these are interpolated resolutions. These numbers are often misleading and should not be considered as yardsticks to support your buying decision—we recommend that you take test prints before a purchase.

The interface that connects a printer to a PC or network is of the utmost importance and should not be overlooked. Most laser printers now support the widely popular USB standard. A printer with an inbuilt Ethernet adapter is also a good thing.

Canon's LBP-2410 comes with just a USB 2.0 port and an optional network adapter that you can later upgrade to. HP's LaserJet 2550L and Lexmark's C510 provide a Parallel and a USB 2.0 port for PC connectivity; they, too, have the option of adding an Ethernet card later on. Wipro's 4160 colour laser printer was the only one with the slower USB 1.1 interface. It does provide a Parallel and an optional Ethernet adapter port for later upgradation.

The Samsung CLP-500 comes with the usual Parallel and USB 2.0 interface, and the Ethernet adapter is optional. However, Samsung has gone one step forward, and has provided optional capability for wireless 802.11b connectivity—a boon for laptop users.

Onboard memory is an important element to consider. To speed up the print process, more

memory always helps—it reduces hard disk access and spooling.

The Samsung CLP-500 and the HP LaserJet 2550L had 64 MB of onboard memory, which can be upgraded to 192 MB. The Lexmark C510, with 64 MB, offers additional room for up to 320 MB. Canon's LBP-2410 has 8 MB of onboard memory, but it uses Canon's proprietary technology—CAPT: Canon Advanced Printing Technology, which permits the printer to use system memory for spooling a print job. This, according to Canon, speeds up data processing, but only if your system has a faster CPU and a decent amount of RAM.

The most common problem with a shared resource, such as a printer is the inability to know how much stationery is available on the printer, before you fire a print request. You thus get irritating "Out of paper" lights blinking at you, instead of the expected printout. Hence, consider paper capacity when you buy a new printer, especially if you expect heavy demands to be placed on the device.

Lexmark's C510 and Samsung's CLP-500 have deep paper trays that can hold 250 paper sheets, followed by the Wipro, which can hold 200 sheets. The Canon and the HP hold 125 sheets each. For additional paper requirements, the Samsung provides an optional 500-sheet paper



The Wipro 4160